

Governed Autonomy: Framework Specification

The complete framework in one document. Every element is marked CORE or EXTENSION. Core elements are mandatory: an implementation that omits one is not an implementation of this framework. Extension elements are contingent or optional: they are adopted when the conditions stated with each element hold, and the adoption decision is recorded in the authority boundaries register. Extension text is shaded and the evidence behind the marking is reported in the accompanying article.

1. Framework map

Element	Topic	Tier	Function in the design
Organizing principle, four clauses	Central	Core	Fixes the authority logic: substantive authority on both sides, progressive instantiation, and authority differentiated by object
X1 Recursive authority clause	Central	Ext.	Extends the principle to the center's own constituted authority
Seven meta-governance functions	Central	Core	The work of the central authority across coherence, enabling, and transition tiers
X2 Coordination and connection	Central	Ext.	Active brokerage between domains and between levels, beyond scheduled flows
X3 Adjacent-authority coordination	Central	Ext.	Standing machinery and decision-rights patterns for compliance counterparts
X7 Segmentation method and design-authority seat	Central	Ext.	A concrete procedure for drawing domain boundaries and catching structural change
Domain decision scope, three patterns and two allocation rules	Domain	Core	Makes domain authority substantive and bounded, down to the attribute layer
Mandatory role set	Domain	Core	An accountable owner plus explicitly resourced business and technical stewardship
Six autonomy conditions	Domain	Core	Gate recognition of a domain's authority on demonstrated capability
X4 Continuity family	Domain	Ext.	Delegates and successor sponsorship protect roles and mandate against turnover
X5 Role and incentive contingencies	Domain	Ext.	Steward placement, owner split, stewardship combination, incentive mix
X6 Data Consumer role	Domain	Ext.	Recognizes and represents the consuming side of the data flow
X8 Recognition instruments	Domain	Ext.	Literacy and maturity measurement behind the conditions
Transition architecture	Transition	Core	Three states, three preconditions, dual onboarding, four hybrid-state mechanisms
X9 Domain selection model	Transition	Ext.	Effort-versus-value scoring with a dual-pilot default
Three governance interfaces	Interface	Core	Register, escalation paths, and accountability channels make the boundary operable
X10 Coordination interfaces	Interface	Ext.	Flow-based working groups where authority is shared rather than delegated
Marketplace gate obligation	Interface	Core	Every transitional safeguard carries a defined removal criterion
X11 Marketplace approval-flow design	Interface	Ext.	Gate count, composition, migration, and staged introduction
Nine core anti-patterns	Anti pattern	Core	Structural failure modes with countermeasures inside the core
Three extension anti-patterns	Anti pattern	Ext	Failure modes whose countermeasures are extension components

Blue rows: core. Yellow rows: extension set.

CORE 2. Organizing principle

The framework is organized around governed autonomy: domain-level actors hold genuine decision authority over data within their defined scope, and that authority is constituted by the structures the central authority maintains. Autonomy is not the absence of governance; it is governance correctly distributed between levels.

Starting off, domain authority is substantive. The decisions allocated to domains are made by domains, not referred to the center for approval or constrained by centrally imposed preferences. An arrangement in which the center can override domain decisions at will is centralized governance with a federated vocabulary.

On the other side, the central authority must be equally substantive. The center's meta-governance functions are authoritative within their defined scope, not advisory. If domains can ignore the center without institutional consequence, the arrangement lacks the coherence that makes it sustainable.

Third, governed autonomy is instantiated progressively. Domains move through governance states asynchronously, and a domain becomes autonomous when the conditions that make its authority governable are in place, not when the organization declares federation complete.

Fourth, central authority is differentiated by object. The center is authoritative on process, floor standards, and arbitration, which are the conditions of coherence and are not negotiated domain by domain. It is collaborative on content allocation, because what a business concept means, which quality rules fit a domain's data, and how a domain structures itself internally are settled with domains. Authoritative on process, collaborative on content is a single posture, not a compromise between two.

EXTENSION X1. Recursive authority clause

Attaches to: the organizing principle, as a candidate fifth clause. Adopt when: several adjacent compliance authorities hold genuine co-decision power over the center's own scope, or when apex readings of the center are producing friction with them.

The principle applies recursively: the central data authority is itself an autonomous actor whose authority is partially constituted by adjacent compliance structures. On data-access decisions and certain risk classifications it shares decision rights with risk management, privacy, and legal rather than acting unilaterally. Under this clause the center is not the apex of a hierarchy but one actor within a structure of distributed and partially shared authority, which changes how it presents its own decisions to domains: as bounded rather than sovereign.

3. The central data authority

The central authority governs the conditions under which domains govern data, rather than governing data directly. The work of the central authority is split into the coherence, enabling and transition tier. The coherence tier keeps the federation one system through standards and regulations. The enabling tier makes domain governance possible through mandate and providing the right technology. The transition tier operates fully only while authority is being redistributed and becomes latent in the steady state, reactivated whenever a new domain is recognized. Seven functions are core; three further functions and methods at this level are extensions. As domains absorb capability, the center contracts from a center of expertise toward a center of enablement.

CORE 3.1 Standard setting (Coherence)

The center defines enterprise-wide policies, principles, definitions, and interoperability requirements. Policy is rendered machine-executable wherever possible, since at organizational scale computational enforceability is a feasibility requirement rather than an aspiration. Where uniformity is not strictly required, standards are issued as adaptable templates that domains tailor within stated bounds, which is how the framework holds standardization and local fit together. Publishing the policy is the minimal exercise of the center's mandate, not its fulfilment.

CORE 3.2 Boundary maintenance (Coherence)

The center defines and adjusts domain authority scopes, resolves overlaps, and recognizes, consolidates, or divides domains as the organization changes. Boundaries are anchored in the indicators a domain owns and in consumer and data-flow analysis. The inherited organization chart is admissible only as a starting heuristic, because boundaries drawn from reporting lines cut across the flows they are meant to govern. Boundaries are formalized and maintained in the authority boundaries register (Section 5.1) and reviewed whenever domain scope changes.

EXTENSION X7. Segmentation method and design-authority seat

Attaches to: boundary maintenance. Adopt when: domains are being drawn for the first time, or redrawn after reorganization, merger, or divestment. The core's boundary obligations hold whether or not this particular method is used.

Segmentation is treated as a multidimensional process across data objects, organizational layers, applications, and geography, and its effort is routinely underestimated. The procedure begins from the indicators each domain owns and the flows through which consumers use its data, and boundaries are then negotiated in center-facilitated, activity-level RACI workshops, the same mechanism that produces the

register. In addition, governance holds a permanent seat in the enterprise design-authority or portfolio body, so that boundary-relevant organizational change reaches the center as it arises rather than after the fact.

CORE 3.3 Conflict arbitration (Coherence)

The center provides a pre-specified process for resolving disputes between domains and between domains and the center. Horizontal resolution between the parties precedes central arbitration, and the center is the final arbiter. Pre-specification matters as much as the ruling itself, because a dispute without a defined forum either result in bad relation or escalates straight to executives.

CORE 3.4 Compliance monitoring (Coherence)

The center tracks whether domain-level governance meets organizational requirements, detecting non-compliance through indicators rather than ad hoc audits. It owns the guideline layer; domains execute against it and evidence their compliance. Monitoring is directed at the requirements of data assets and processes, not at the evaluation of individuals.

CORE 3.5 Platform and tooling stewardship (Enabling)

The center provides and maintains the central platform, catalogue, lineage tooling, quality monitoring, and marketplace, and designs the approval flows through which governance is enforced computationally instead of manual review. Stewardship spans the hybrid, multi-platform landscape most large organizations actually run, which requires situating governance and semantics at the data layer of the reference architecture rather than binding them to a single platform.

CORE 3.6 Stakeholder mandate maintenance (Enabling)

The center secures and continuously sustains executive sponsorship, manages expectations upward and downward, deploys a persuasion repertoire, and maintains a pipeline of candidates for domain roles. In a federated arrangement the center's power is substantially borrowed, so the borrowing must be organized and renewed rather than assumed. A mandate is most effectively established through persuasion before enforcement, particularly in relationships across different domains. This approach is strengthened when the business case emphasizes value creation rather than the threat of penalties, since compliance-driven arguments alone are unlikely to sustain commitment throughout a multi-year transition. In this context, genuine sponsorship is demonstrated not by verbal expressions of support, but by the willingness to allocate sufficient time and resources. The language used to describe the initiative also matters. If the term governance creates resistance, the work can instead be presented through the outcomes it enables and the value it contributes. The release of sufficient time is invariant; the wider incentive mix is contingent (X5).

CORE 3.7 Capability transfer (Transition)

Latent in the steady state. The center supports the development of data-management practices within domains by embedding staff or recruiting directly into domain teams. It also designs and delivers mandatory onboarding and monitors whether these practices continue beyond the initial training period. As domains gradually develop the required capabilities and take greater ownership, the center reduces its direct involvement. The function exists because accountability moves to domains before capability does, and the tier has an explicit end state: the center contracts toward a center of enablement and reactivates transfer when new domains enter.

EXTENSION X2. Coordination and connection

Attaches to: the enabling tier. Adopt when: the domain count is high, maturity is widely spread across domains, or individual domains are large enough to require internal coordination structures of their own.

The center acts as connector between domains, between business and technology, and between operational stewards and senior accountable owners, ensuring cross-domain visibility through catalogues and marketplaces. What this adds beyond the core accountability channels is active brokerage rather than scheduled reporting. Coordination intensity is calibrated per domain against maturity rather than applied uniformly, and very large domains may run nested coordination structures internally.

EXTENSION X3. Adjacent-authority coordination

Attaches to: the enabling tier, and operates the third allocation pattern of Section 4.1. Adopt when: multiple compliance authorities hold intersecting claims on data decisions, which describes most large organizations. The core requires in any case that shared-decision routes exist, are documented, and have been tested.

A permanent function maintains working relationships and shared-decision routes with five categories of adjacent authority: risk management, data privacy, legal, security, and the information management office. The center acts as the domains' single front door into this landscape, so that a requester faces one route rather than several separately owned procedures. The function is permanent because its load scales with the number of compliance counterparts, which growing domain maturity does not reduce.

For each decision type that intersects an adjacent authority, the decision-rights relationship is articulated in one of three patterns. Where the adjacent authority leads, as with sensitivity classification, retention periods, and data protection impact assessments, the center follows its guidance while mitigation choices may remain with the center within constraints. Under co-decision, as with approving data products containing sensitive content, major access decisions, and cross-cutting policy design, both authorities sign off and either can block, with sign-off procedural and time-bounded. Where the center leads, as with domain definition, role assignment, marketplace design, and platform tooling, it decides and the adjacent authority is consulted without holding a veto.

Two risks require standing countermeasures. Inward function creep pulls the center into work outside its formal scope because no other team can do it and outward function creep sees its work bleed into territory adjacent authorities already own. The countermeasures are advocacy without ownership, and review of the authority register on the same cadence as domain boundary review. Over time, the accumulation of governance responsibilities across compliance structures may generate pressure toward a unified governance authority; the framework governs the present multi-authority landscape and treats convergence as a possible evolution to be monitored through those reviews rather than presumed. Associated anti-pattern: authority confusion (Section 7).

4. Domain governance authority

A domain is organized around three things: a defined scope of decisions, a role architecture through which to exercise them, and the conditions under which its autonomy is recognized.

CORE 4.1 Decision scope

Domain authority is defined by an explicit allocation of decision classes across three patterns, documented in the authority boundaries register. Delegated to the domain are business definitions of domain-specific concepts, the design of quality rules within central constraints, the domain's internal sub-structure, the selection of consumer use cases, and domain-specific access requests. Reserved to or co-decided with the center are cross-domain definitions of shared entities, classifications that affect regulatory exposure, lineage and metadata standards, and tooling choices that touch the central platform. Co-decided with or led by adjacent authorities are sensitivity classifications, retention periods, data protection impact assessments, and access decisions for sensitive data products. The core requires that the routes for this third pattern exist, are documented, while the standing machinery for operating them is X3.

Under the attribute-layer rule, globally shared attributes of a common entity are governed centrally while locally specific attributes of that same entity are governed by the domain, so the unit of allocation is the attribute layer rather than the entity. This granularity is what makes residual centralization detectable. Under the producer-owns-semantics rule, the producing domain owns the semantic definition of a shared entity, consuming domains submit change requests against it, and the center arbitrates where producer and consumers cannot agree.

CORE 4.2 Mandatory role set

The core role architecture is deliberately minimal: an accountable owner, and explicitly resourced stewardship covering both business and technical responsibilities. The Domain Data Owner is accountable for the domain's data assets, signs off on classification, ownership assignment, and access decisions, and represents the domain in cross-domain arbitration; the owner must complete mandatory onboarding training

and remain verifiably active thereafter. Stewardship carries operational responsibility for definitions, quality rules, and the business meaning of data, and for translating those definitions and rules into technical implementation while maintaining the mapping between business concepts and physical assets.

Technical stewardship is a first-class, explicitly resourced obligation rather than an assumed by-product of the platform team's work. Without it, quality rules remain announcements: the business side of stewardship typically cannot convert rules into pipelines, validation checks, and platform configurations, and governance stays on paper. How stewardship is organized and placed is contingent (X5).

EXTENSION X5. Role and incentive contingencies

Attaches to: the mandatory role set and mandate maintenance. Adopt when: the governing variables named below take values that favor one configuration over another; record the choice and its rationale in the register.

Technical stewards may sit in a central pool serving all domains, be embedded within domains so that domains own and maintain the artifacts produced, or be trained within domains under central guidance as an intermediate model. The choice is governed by platform complexity, domain data volume, and skill scarcity, and it trades local ownership against scarce expertise. The Domain Data Owner role may be split into strategic and operational variants where the business and the domain's size warrant it. Stewardship may be combined in a single steward covering business and technical responsibilities, dividing when scope or complexity grows, and the strict separation may relax as domain literacy increases. The incentive mix may include integration into job descriptions, dedicated time budgets, recognition, and, where reward policy allows, remuneration. Incentives never substitute for released time, which is core. Terminology is anchored to the DAMA concept of the data custodian so that roles stay legible across organizations.

EXTENSION X4. Continuity family

Attaches to: the role set, the executive-mandate precondition, and the hybrid-state mechanisms, where it forms a fifth mechanism. Adopt when: turnover risk is material and the transition is planned in years, which is the framework's own expectation for the hybrid state.

For each substantive role a designated, trained delegate maintains continuity through absence and turnover. Without delegates the role architecture is brittle, and a single absence can stall a domain's governance. The same logic extends upward to sponsorship. The mandate is institutional, anchored in a board or steering structure and supported by a named successor sponsor, so that the program survives a change of executive. Together these provisions protect the transition against the churn of the people carrying it. Associated anti-pattern: brittle role architecture (Section 7).

EXTENSION X6. Data Consumer role

Attaches to: the role architecture, outside the autonomy conditions. Adopt when: significant consumption occurs outside the producing domains. Pair with X10, which supplies the venue in which consumers are represented.

The architecture recognizes the Data Consumer: the analyst or consuming function that takes governed data out of a domain and builds reporting or products on it. A consumer may belong to no domain, one, or several, and may sit outside the conditions for autonomy. Each domain identifies its consumers explicitly, and consumers are jointly represented in cross-domain coordination. The rationale is an asymmetry the role architecture otherwise reproduces: governance attention concentrates where data is produced, while its value and its potential misuse arise where it is consumed.

CORE 4.3 Six autonomy conditions

A domain's decisions are recognized as autonomous rather than provisional when six conditions hold simultaneously. The substantive roles are filled. The owner has completed mandatory onboarding training and remains verifiably active in the central authority's accountability flows afterwards. The domain's critical data elements are identified, governed by quality rules running in production on the central platform, and reviewed on a defined revalidation cadence, both when data changes are reported and at scheduled intervals, because the critical-data inventory decays as systems and reporting change. Lineage from source systems to consumer use is demonstrable for critical data. The domain has a defined escalation path into the central authority and demonstrably uses it. And the owner accepts, and is held to, a domain-level indicator on data-management compliance.

A domain meeting fewer than all six may hold partial autonomy over business definitions and quality-rule design while the center retains the remaining decision rights. Partial autonomy is read diagnostically, as a capability gap that targeted transfer is intended to close, not as a sanction. The activity-after-training condition is the one most easily lost, which is why autonomy is defined by sustained activity rather than by completed training, and recognition rests throughout on demonstrated rather than asserted capability. These domain-level conditions differ in kind from the organization-level preconditions of Section 6.2: preconditions determine whether delegation may begin at all, while conditions determine whether a particular domain's decisions are recognized.

EXTENSION X8. Recognition instruments

Attaches to: the demonstrated-capability requirement of the conditions. Adopt when: recognition decisions are contested, or capability claims cannot otherwise be verified. Treat scores as decision support rather than decision automation.

Two instruments operationalize demonstrated capability. A literacy measurement taken before and after governance onboarding makes capability gain visible, and doubles as a diagnostic for where transfer effort should go next. A recurring per-domain maturity assessment defines what good performance looks like for that domain and baselines the six conditions against it, so that recognition is a reading rather than a judgment call.

5. Governance interfaces

Interfaces make the boundary between central and domain authority operable and keep the arrangement from devolving into silos or re-centralizing. Three are core; two further interfaces are extensions, with the core retaining the obligations they serve.

CORE 5.1 Authority boundaries register

The register documents which decisions belong to the center, which to the domain, which are co-decided with the center, and which are shared with or owned by adjacent authorities. Decision rights are negotiated at the level of specific activities in center-facilitated workshops, formalized through a responsibility-assignment matrix, maintained through ongoing boundary management, and reviewed whenever a domain's scope changes. Undocumented boundaries are a primary cause of scoping disputes, which makes the register the first concrete artifact an implementation produces and the reference against which later disputes are settled.

CORE 5.2 Escalation paths

Escalation combines a horizontal stage with a three-tier vertical structure. Before any vertical escalation, a peer-resolution stage convenes the stewards of the affected domains, and only what they cannot resolve ascends. Most content disputes are resolvable by those who hold the content knowledge. The vertical pathway runs an operational tier in the form of a Data Quality Board of business and technical stewards with central representation, a domain-lead tier bringing together Domain Data Owners and senior central representatives, and an executive tier in the form of a Data Governance Board with executive representation reporting to the steering committee, each with a defined meeting cadence and level of reporting detail. Executive accountability is verified rather than assumed: an officer who acts only as an approver, without an enforceable indicator, fails the tier and, by extension, the mandate precondition.

CORE 5.3 Accountability channels

The communication structure is based on scheduled, bidirectional information flows with clearly identified senders and receivers. At the domain level, regularly updated performance dashboards provide visibility into ongoing progress and are discussed in governance sessions whose frequency reflects each domain's level of maturity. These sessions are complemented by a monthly collective forum with dedicated time slots for each domain, creating cross-domain visibility without relying on broad, one-way communication. Central communications to domains are accompanied by implementation support, while the center reports to executive sponsors according to an agreed cadence. Importantly, the center's own performance indicators are shared through the same channels and are made as visible to domains as domain indicators are to the center. This reciprocity is what differentiates accountability from surveillance.

EXTENSION X10. Coordination interfaces for shared authority

Attaches to: the governance interfaces. The core retains the obligation that a deliberately designed venue exists wherever authority is shared across domains. Adopt when: material data flows cross domain boundaries and require joint decisions rather than delegation.

Shared authority is governed through cross-domain working groups organized around a data flow rather than a domain, seating producers and consumers together. These groups require deliberate design, as they are unlikely to emerge effectively on their own. Without a defined structure, the operational escalation tier can gradually become the main forum for cross-domain coordination, placing design responsibilities on a body intended primarily for dispute resolution. Each group should therefore have a clear owner, charter, and meeting cadence before it can be considered a formal interface. If a chartered group is no longer actively attended or used, it should be reintegrated into the operational tier rather than maintained only in name.

CORE 5.4 Marketplace gate obligation

When data products are published and requested through a marketplace, the approval process should be treated as a governance interface rather than merely as a platform feature. A key principle is that every approval gate introduced as a temporary safeguard should include a clear removal criterion from the moment it is established. Such gates are often necessary during the early stages of a transition because the governance system has not yet reached sufficient maturity. However, without predefined conditions for their removal, they can remain in place long after their original purpose has disappeared. This creates unnecessary friction and may weaken the engagement on which the transition depends. The complete design of this approval flow is described in X11.

EXTENSION X11. Marketplace approval-flow design

Attaches to: platform stewardship and the marketplace gate obligation. Adopt when: a marketplace is in operation or being built. Where platform capability is immature, adopt the staging provision and declare the marketplace a target-state interface rather than assuming operational capability.

The design of the flow answers three questions. The number of gates: at steady state there are at least two, a central gate and a domain-owner gate, with further gates introduced only where a decision type cannot be governed within that pair. Each approval gate should clearly define the responsible authority, the criteria for sign-off, the conditions under which the gate may be bypassed, and the requirements for its eventual removal. The flow should then evolve according to domain maturity rather than a fixed organization-wide timetable, allowing safeguards to be withdrawn once a domain demonstrates the required level of capability. The marketplace should follow a similar introduction, with its intended end state made explicit in the transition plan while the necessary platform capabilities continue to mature. Ultimately, each domain should be able to publish data products independently under common standards and remain accountable for the business indicators it owns. A key anti-pattern to avoid is the permanent transitional gate discussed in Section 7.

6. Transition architecture

CORE 6.1 Three governance states

In the centralized state the center performs all meta-governance and most operational governance, and domains may have data users and producers but hold no decision rights. In the hybrid state some domains hold autonomy under the six conditions while others remain under direct central control or are mid-onboarding. In this scenario, the center operates all its functions simultaneously with effort distributed unequally. This state is expected to last the longest, not because the architecture has failed, but because domains progress at different rates. As each domain meets the required conditions independently, the organization remains in a hybrid state until all in-scope domains have completed the transition. In the federated steady state, all in-scope domains operate with autonomy, while capability transfer remains available when needed. The center continues to function as a small enabling unit alongside increasingly capable domains rather than disappearing entirely. The level of residual central support will depend on the specific needs of the organization, and the model does not assume that every domain will become fully self-sufficient. Organizations that begin from a fragmented rather than centralized structure should first establish a governable baseline. Delegation can then proceed once sufficient consistency and coordination have been achieved.

CORE 6.2 Organization-level preconditions

All delegation depends on three preconditions that together reduce the risk of fragmentation. The first is an active executive mandate. An executive sponsor must accept accountability for the program and support it with an allocated budget and an enforceable enterprise-level indicator for data-management compliance. This mandate must be demonstrated in practice. At a minimum, this requires a published policy and formally issued indicators, meaning that executive approval without continued direction is insufficient. The mandate should also be framed positively around value creation.

The second precondition is the availability of a central platform that provides the core capabilities required for consistent governance across domains. At a minimum, this includes a catalogue, quality monitoring, lineage capability, and a marketplace with a defined approval process. It should also include policy-as-code capability, since machine-executable policy at organizational scale is a prerequisite for effective implementation.

The third precondition is alignment with adjacent authorities. Functions such as risk, privacy, and legal should be consulted on the center's plans before delegation begins. The routes through which shared decisions are made should also be documented and tested in practice, ensuring that responsibilities and escalation paths are clear before authority is transferred to domains.

CORE 6.3 Selection and the governance-first rule

Domains enter the transition through a deliberate selection process led by the center rather than through voluntary or ad hoc participation. The order in which domains are brought into the transition is therefore a strategic decision based on organizational priorities. Within each domain, governance activities should always begin before, or at least alongside, technical integration. This sequencing helps prevent reactive governance, where controls are introduced only after a data request has been made, and instead supports the proactive identification and governance of critical data.

EXTENSION X9. Domain selection model

Attaches to: selection, after the preconditions hold. Adopt when: a delegation wave is being planned. The core rules of deliberate selection and governance-before-integration apply whether or not this model is used.

Candidate domains are scored on an effort-versus-value matrix. Value inputs include regulatory exposure, the concentration of organization-level critical data elements, business value anchored in the indicators a domain owns, and owner readiness and willingness. Effort inputs cover integration complexity and capability distance. The final selection is conditioned on the organization's risk appetite. Where the organization has little prior evidence that federated governance works, the default is a dual pilot pairing one quick-win domain that produces early visible value with one demonstrably high-value domain, so that the transition earns its mandate while attacking a problem that matters. In heavily regulated sectors, regulatory criticality legitimately occupies the high-value slot, because supervisory mechanisms concentrate consequences there, therefore the regulatory-first ordering is a special case.

CORE 6.4 Dual onboarding

Two processes commonly conflated under the single word onboarding are kept distinct, because they have different owners, timelines, and success criteria. Technical onboarding integrates the domain's data into the central platform, from feasibility assessment through transfer and packaging into collections to quality monitoring in production. It is owned by the platform function, and it succeeds when data is available with monitoring in place. Governance onboarding assigns owners and stewards, delivers mandatory training, validates sustained governance activity beyond the training period, and integrates the domain into established accountability flows. This is owned by the governance function, and it succeeds only when the domain meets all six autonomy conditions. Treating technical onboarding as completed governance onboarding creates the appearance of governance because a domain's data is available on the platform, while owner activity has never been verified.

CORE 6.5 Hybrid-state mechanisms

The hybrid state should be actively managed and not treated as a temporary condition to be endured. Central support is deliberately uneven, with the center directing greater effort toward the least mature in-scope domains through capability transfer, role assignment, and direct involvement in data quality, while applying lighter coordination mechanisms to more mature domains. A visible indicator tree provides continuous transparency on domain compliance with the policy set and applies equivalent performance measures to the center itself. The model also allows for reversibility when necessary. If a domain no longer meets the conditions required for autonomy, it returns temporarily to direct central governance based on indicator thresholds agreed at the point of delegation. This intervention is framed as temporary support, with the center acting as a standing backstop, and autonomy is restored once the same thresholds are met again. Domain boundaries may also be consolidated or divided as organizational needs evolve. Communication is maintained through the domain-specific sessions and collective forum described in Section 5.3, while program continuity is addressed separately in X4.

7. Anti-pattern register

The framework makes twelve recurring failure modes structurally identifiable, each tied to a design countermeasure. Nine countermeasures sit in the core; three travel with the extension components that constitute them. Prospectively the register is a design checklist, since an implementation that cannot state how it prevents a given anti-pattern is incomplete. Diagnostically it supplies a shared vocabulary for naming decay before it hardens, and it is reviewed periodically against live evidence.

Anti-pattern	Description	Countermeasure	Tier
Excused absence	The center uses federation as a reason to stop setting standards or monitoring compliance.	The central functions are obligations; federation relieves the center of none of them.	Core
Nominal federation	Domains are formally autonomous, but every decision still routes through central approval.	Decision rights mapped to the attribute layer, the granularity at which residual centralization becomes detectable.	Core
Fragmentation	Domains receive autonomy without capability or platform support; incompatible local arrangements proliferate.	Autonomy conditions; organization-level preconditions; capability transfer; consolidation-first entry.	Core
Reactive governance	The center acts only when a consumer requests data; no proactive identification of critical data.	Governance precedes or parallels integration; critical data identified and governed proactively; scheduled accountability flows.	Core
One-way communication	The center broadcasts policy and receives no signal back.	Bidirectional channels with named senders and receivers; per-domain sessions with the timeboxed collective forum.	Core
Domain definition by inertia	Domain boundaries follow the inherited organization chart rather than data flows.	Boundary maintenance anchored in owned indicators and consumer analysis; the chart admissible only as a heuristic.	Core
Missing technical stewardship	Business stewards are assigned; technical stewards are left implicit.	Technical stewardship as a first-class, explicitly resourced obligation.	Core
Mandate failure	The center is structurally peer-level, holds no enforceable indicator, and depends on persuasion alone.	Mandate maintenance; exercised-mandate precondition; verified executive escalation tier.	Core
Onboarding conflation	Technical onboarding is treated as completed governance onboarding; owner activity is unverified.	Two onboarding processes with distinct owners and success criteria; activity after training as a condition.	Core
Brittle role architecture	Roles are filled but no delegates exist; a single absence stalls domain governance.	Delegate provisions with continuity extended upward to sponsorship (X4).	Ext.
Authority confusion	Domain, center, and adjacent authority act on the same decision without clarity on whose call it is.	Adjacent boundaries in the register; the three decision-rights patterns; single front door (X3).	Ext.
Permanent transitional gate	A safeguard gate becomes permanent because no removal criterion was specified.	Documented removal pathway per gate; per-domain, maturity-based gate migration (X11).	Ext.

Blue rows: countermeasures inside the core. Yellow rows: countermeasures supplied by extension components.

8. Recorded candidate

CANDIDATE X12. Growth-stage reduced configuration

Not part of the framework in either tier. Recorded so that the proposal is not lost and so that the full framework is not mistaken for a scale-up prescription.

Organizations in the growth stage, becoming multi-domain but far below the complexity the full apparatus presupposes, might adapt a deliberately minimal variant: a reduced role set, a single governance body, and a reduced condition set, expanding toward the core as domain count and complexity grow. The configuration has not been specified or tested, and it should not be adopted as though it had been.